had not spoken of their judicial independence: on the contrary he had in relation to them put in place a system of scrutiny. The reasons for taking a diametrically opposite view in relation to rajukkas is not clear, but the result would have been administrative decentralization.

Ashoka's views are also here spelt out on the death penalty, and in some detail; as in virtually every sphere of administration, he comes out here as the prototype of benevolence. If the *Arthashastra* is to be believed, the penalty was prescribed for a range of offences: the sale of human flesh, killing a person (even by accident), supplying murderers and thieves with counsel or nourishment, acts against the king and the kingdom, stealing weapons, and some other crimes considered heinous.[29] Ashoka is silent about the offences that the condemned prisoners alluded to in this edict are charged with, but orders that there be an interlude of three days from the time punishment is pronounced by the rajukkas to when condemned prisoners are led to the gallows. The respite was to allow the relatives of prisoners on death row to appeal against such decisions, or, as Ashoka's edict put it, so that relatives of the accused could persuade rajukkas to reconsider. Simultaneously, the interlude might ensure a more dignified death by allowing the condemned time to prepare: 'they will bestow gifts or will undergo fasts in order to (attain happiness) in the other (world). For my desire is this, that, even when the time (of respite) has expired, they should attain (happiness) in the other (world).'[30] Ashoka appears to have had very ambivalent feelings about the death sentence but did not get it removed from the state's judicial provisions. He did, however, on as many as twenty-five occasions from the time of his anointment, release prisoners, and some of these were conceivably commutations.[31]

A slew of substantive injunctions against the killing of animals, birds, and fish constitute another dimension of the emperor's exceptionally humane provisions. From the modern ecological perspective this edict is without doubt the most substantive royal public message in early India, and